

All Jewish pupils expelled from German schools
War started by Germany invading Poland
UK and France declare war on Germany.

1938 when the impossible became possible

Kristallnacht (Night of Broken Glass)
Austria, and the Sudetenland; 200
shops looted; 30,000 male Jews
Buchenwald, Sachsenhausen

nd: 200 synagogues destroyed; 7,500 Jewish
Jews sent to concentration camps (Dachau,
en)

My Childhood

Early memories

When my memory goes back into babyhood, certain recollections are quite sharp.

My father came into the nursery quite often between patients, watching my development, enquiring about my diet and my health.

In those days, washing nappies without washing machines or suitable places to dry them presented major problems. Washerwomen had to be employed at least twice a week. The housekeeper cooked special meals for them; the very process interrupted a professional practice, at least in the capital. So, babies had to be nappy trained as soon as possible, most were clean before their first birthday without lasting psychological damage. These days with washing machines and disposable nappies children aged three and four are still not trained and are disrupting nursery classes.

There is a particular incident I remember vividly when I was about three. My mother took me for a walk in the sparkling spring sunshine in Andrásy Street. There were crowds gathering waving flags. My mother's hat was blown away by a gust of wind, which I found incredibly funny, so I laughed out loud. The flag waving was to celebrate the visit of Eugenio Pacelli, the Cardinal Secretary of State, who passed by in his motorcade in an open car¹².

¹² Eugenio Pacelli became Pope Pius XII shortly after the Budapest visit. He is viewed as a controversial figure. On the one hand, he appointed several Jewish scholars to posts in the Vatican after they were dismissed as a result of Mussolini's racial laws and later, when deportations of Italian Jews began, his actions saved many when 477 were hidden in the Vatican with a further 4238 protected in Roman monasteries and convents. He was also involved in the rescue action after the German occupation of Hungary in March 1944. Under the leadership of the Pope's senior representative in Budapest, the Papal Nuncio Angelo Rotta, the diplomats of eight neutral countries represented in the Hungarian capital — including the Swedish ambassador and his staff, prominent among them Per Anger and Raoul Wallenberg — organized a city-wide rescue scheme. However, he has also been much criticised for not doing more to challenge the Nazis

My mother took me for long walks in a succession of prams, organised children's parties, later took me to a nursery or a cinema and might even have taught me to read. I picked up reading very quickly and became an avid reader of just about anything I found in my father's vast library.

My Godparents Irene and Jenő Strinovich

In his efforts to get assimilated into society and to shield me from persecution my father had me christened. As far as I know neither he, nor my mother converted to Christianity; they were agnostic, but thought that having me christened would protect me.

My godparents were from a very devout military family. The husband was a general belonging to Horthy's¹³ inner circle. They lived in an elegantly furnished flat overlooking the Danube. As well as giving me a beautifully illustrated leather-bound antique Bible they appeared on my name day every year, they also gave me a delicious cheesecake, even in hard times, when ingredients were almost impossible to get and when they themselves lived in abject poverty.

My godmother was a patient of my father's. As well as her psychiatric problems, she had a habit of choking on fish bones. She and her husband had a small cottage to the south of Budapest on the river Danube, where the tasty but bony local fish, the *keszeg* became their staple diet. Her attempts at filleting the fish were so unprofessional and she ate with such great haste that she often ended up coming by taxi gasping and choking to be delivered onto my father's operating table.

When the first anti-Jewish laws came out they tried to protect us by arranging for us to move out of Budapest. Sadly, their efforts were to no avail but nobody anticipated at that time, what was to follow.

¹³ Miklós Horthy de Nagybánya (1868-1957) was the Regent of the Kingdom of Hungary from 1920 until the Nazi invasion of March 1944. Whilst Horthy had been an ally of Hitler's early in the war, his reluctance to contribute to the German war effort and participate in the Holocaust led to the invasion and his arrest by the Nazis. He was replaced by his right-wing deputy Ferenc Szálasi, who enthusiastically engaged with the Germans in deporting the Jews of Hungary to the death camps. He was a witness at the Nuremberg war-crime trials and then went into exile in Portugal. His elder son, serving as a fighter pilot during the war, died in a flying accident at the Russian front. His younger son was kidnapped by German commandos and unknown to him was taken to Dachau concentration camp, where other non-Jewish undesirables, like gypsies, English prisoners of war, and left-wing intellectuals were also imprisoned. He was freed by the Americans and joined his father in Portugal

After the war, they came to see us. Their flat had been destroyed and they were destitute, dressed in many layers of rags, living in their one room cottage near the Danube

My godfather, past 70 years of age, was forced to work on a road construction project breaking stones. He joked that he had a diplomatic job. In Hungarian, if you reverse:

"I break stones" it becomes "Török követ," I am a Turkish ambassador."

My father gave them money and warm clothes to survive the winter. Their courage and dignity always impressed me.

Csumi, the singing dachshund

My father was very fond of his pet dachshund Csumi, who was a lovely rich rust colour and very lively and affectionate. He took her for long walks in the evenings and thought she was so bright, she could almost talk.

Csumi loved music and always attended the concerts at home, where she chose a prominent position and acted as an accompanist. I myself had piano lessons for years, but never reached the required standard. Csumi just sat there, stretched her neck and pointed her nose upwards and started to sing in the most terrible falsetto voice, but roughly keeping with the melody.

Nobody dared to suggest, that she should be taken out or locked up. It was just too hilarious.

Liszt Ferenc Square 4

Going back to the top floor of my father's house in my imagination, (in reality I have never returned to Hungary after fleeing in 1956) I can see that it represented a typical cross section of Jewish society.

On the top floor, there were four apartments. Next to us lived the Frankl family. Zolti, more than 10 years younger than my father, was a distinguished dental surgeon, with beautiful sculpturesque wife Anuci and two children born 16 years apart. Andrew Frankl was three years younger than I was. He was obsessed with fast trains. As a schoolboy, he was capable of waiting more than half an hour for the fast train called the stuka, which had a clear run on the underground, all other trains being cleared out of the way.

I think he could have comfortably walked this distance in the time he waited. He kept this fascination with speed all his life and in spite of parental pressure to enter the medical profession went into journalism, publishing motoring magazines. Later he was asked to officiate on prize giving and other occasions, mixing with the most glamorous racing drivers and royalty.

He married an English girl, who turned out to be totally unsuitable match and, in spite of his children's opposition, they divorced. His great love from Hungary, Susie, went to the USA with her mother and married an older but very glamorous and wealthy man. After 30 years and three children, the husband died, and she and Andrew accidentally met up again and married. They are the happiest romantic couple and Vera, his younger sister, who became a distinguished BBC journalist, wrote a radio play called *Autumn Leaves* about their story. It was broadcast all over the world causing traffic problems as people reached for their hankies in their cars.

In 1944 Zolti, the father, was taken to Mauthausen concentration camp. He grabbed his bag of surgical instruments as he was leaving: that action saved his life and those of many others. 12 years later he became a refugee for the second time. He had to qualify all over again in Britain, revising from books that quoted his own articles in the bibliography.

Next to us lived the Marbach family. Both parents perished in Auschwitz and the grandparents did their best after the war to bring up their granddaughter, who was about the same age as me.

The girl was completely traumatized; you could hardly get a word out of her.

The owners of the fourth apartment managed to escape and ended up in Israel, leaving their apartment empty, with the exception of a small maid's room, which was let to a couple, who were informers. They denounced people to both the Nazis and later to the Communists.

The porter and his family lived in the basement. They were decent people, trying to protect the properties in their charge during the war.

We were not so lucky in my mother's flat. Lala Mama had bought an expensive piece of jewellery to be used in an emergency. We left it with the porters for safe keeping but they would not let us have it back.

My First Artistic Inspiration

One of the things that I remember most clearly was the furniture in my father's flat. It was an inspiration to me from my earliest years. It was light, spacious, experimental and totally unconventional. It was designed by the Bauhaus architect and designer Herbert Bayer¹⁴, who was a relative, son of my father's cousin Aladár Bayer. Herbert had a sister named Agota, Goti for short after whom I was named.

The furniture would look a cutting-edge concept even today and influenced my whole approach to art

It consisted mainly of square units affixed to the walls, a different colour used in every room. These units were supported by chromium tubes that were screwed to the floor. These units housed many different things, a bed folded out of one or a side table out of another leaving the floor totally unencumbered. The living room furniture was made of a polished brown laminate, which included a rather ingenious square coffee table, which could be opened up in 4 individual leaves lined with beige plastic or linoleum for eating or card playing. We used this more often than the formal dining suite. The storage area could be opened up to reveal a glittering mirrored bar cabinet with a variety of drinks bottles. Next to this there was a sideboard full of plates and silver cutlery and while the next cabinet housed the famous linen dowry my grandmother had put so much effort into assembling.

The living room, which doubled up as a waiting room for the patients as well as a music room for concerts, featured a large oval settee with woven bamboo cane backing and elephant grey velvet upholstery accompanied by two matching armchairs. The room of course had an inevitable padded door to keep the privacy of the patients and the music practice which my father so diligently pursued.

The units in my room were coloured between beige and pink, and used to display the dozens of dolls that I had received as presents by friends and patients. I had a most ingenious round table in the same colour supported by four planks slotted into the surface at right angles supporting a lower deck of storage space. The bed folded out from one of the square units.

I cannot remember seeing a double bed in my parent's room and strangely there were no full-length wardrobes for clothes in the rooms themselves. Clothes were hung in the full height units in the hall.

My Father's Rooms

Bayer did not design our sofa and armchairs but otherwise, my father's consulting rooms were the only place which largely

¹⁴ Bayer (1900-1985) studied at the Bauhaus had studied for four years under such teachers as Wassily Kandinsky, Paul Klee and László Moholy-Nagy and was then appointed director of printing and advertising. In 1928, he became art director of Vogue magazine's Berlin office. He left Germany for the USA in 1937 after his work was included in the Degenerate Art Exhibition and built up a very successful career as corporate designer for the oil company ARCO

escaped the designer's touch, although his small and sober self-portrait, painted in egg tempera was near the door. You first entered a very long room in which there stood a huge carved antique desk in front of brown ribbed curtains.

The walls were lined with books in double rows, literature from all over the world, poetry, scientific books, maps and encyclopaedias. The range was enormous and I had absolutely free choice to borrow or browse from this treasure trove. Some of the scientific books also came with intriguing illustrations and photographs. There were not many children's books in Hungary in those days, except the Grimm's fairy tales which I heartily disliked.

There were also plenty of illustrated books translated by the best writers and poets in Hungary, a tradition which is still alive, subsidised originally by some well-meaning aristocrats and more recently by the state. My favourite books included Thackeray's *Vanity Fair* and *The Book of Snobs*, illustrated by the author; I also loved Gulliver's Travels with its illustrations by Luis Read¹⁵. Victor Hugo¹⁶ was a great writer but also an accomplished draftsman. I also loved *In Praise of Folly* by Erasmus¹⁷, which was illustrated by Holbein and William Blake's *The Songs of Innocence and Experience*¹⁸, which was of course written and illustrated by the artist himself.

Beyond the consulting room was the surgery proper with an operating table, cabinets for medicines and surgical instruments and some very expensive modern equipment including, the ultrasound and infrared machines, I have been recently treated with miniaturized versions of these but in those days, they were like large fridges whereas now they are the size of mobile phones. There was a sink and sterilising equipment as well as an en suite modern bathroom. The father's large leather bag was always at the ready and restocked regularly as doctors could be called upon in an emergency day or night.

¹⁵ Luis Quintinalla (1893-1978) was a Spanish artist and illustrator who created twenty four original prints and one hundred and sixty drawings by my father for the 1947 edition of *Gulliver's Travels* published by Crown

¹⁶ Hugo (1802-1885), the celebrated author of *Les Misérables* and *The Hunchback of Notre-Dame*, produced more than 4,000 drawings which he kept out of the public eye, but shared with family and friends

¹⁷ *In Praise of Folly* was first published in 1511 by the great Humanist writer Erasmus of Rotterdam (1466-1536)

¹⁸ A series of illustrated poems by the English poet and artist William Blake (1757-1827)

My Education

And so, it happened that when I started school aged seven, we were taught the hand signals of the alphabet, (a particularly silly method in my opinion) and I failed in reading, while secretly enjoying my favourite books under the desk. My parents were called in, but in the end, it was decided to leave me alone as much more serious problems were looming on the horizon.

At the request of my godmother, I was also sent to Sunday school. With my newly acquired scientific knowledge, I started arguing that angels could not kneel on clouds as the vapour could not possibly support their weight. I am afraid I was soon asked to leave as I was disruptive and just too much trouble.

Living with my Mother

When my parents divorced, I went to live with my mother, very much against my will, as I wanted to stay with my father. However, he was too busy and did not have the facilities to look after me.

It was generally accepted, that raising children was a woman's job and this is what my mother set out to do.

We went to live in a large apartment house in Ferenc Boulevard, one of the main boulevards of Budapest, which she and my grandmother jointly owned. It was a spacious, sunny apartment with a balcony. It had a kind of frosted glass enclosure in the hall, without a ceiling, where our housekeeper, cook, and babysitter Elsa lived.

We took with us half the Herbert Bayer furniture.

Elsa was of Swabian origin. She was discriminated against after the war when there was a pressure to send ethnic Germans back to Germany. She returned voluntarily, but many Swabians, who had lived in Hungary for generations were forcibly deported because they were suspected of being Nazi sympathisers. Elsa returned to live with her family in Munich. She sent me £8 twice a year in order to keep in touch, a rather embarrassing gesture she repeated to the end of her life.

Magda was not a physically demonstrative person; I cannot remember her ever hugging or kissing me, or even stroking me. She treated me as a little friend to accompany her in her activities. She often criticised me as, in spite of her best efforts, I was not strong and was rather shy. She would have enjoyed bringing up my son, who was physically robust and adventurous.

Seeing my shortcomings, she embarked on a program to toughen me up and make me stronger and more self-reliant. In a way, even now, I still want to impress her, and her image appears

in front of me in the patio of our house in Lanzarote in the shape of a little bird, who seems to shriek at me “do it, just do it!”

When I was five years old, I was taken to a nursery on Andrassy Street, which had a narrow garden on the side of the building. After a paved footpath, there were some decorative, but prickly rose bushes growing up against the fence. The boys were constantly bullying and pushing me and other girls around. This could not be tolerated! Magda began to train me in judo. How she acquired these skills is a mystery, but she taught me some basic moves, twisting the arms or crossing the legs of the opponent and throwing them over. When I got it right, she would pretend to fall over in agony. A few weeks later, when the boys started to bully me again, I flung them effortlessly into the rosebushes. They were so surprised, they did not even fight back, just started to cry and complain to the staff and to the mothers who had started to arrive to take them home.

Some ticking off or reprimand was expected, but my mother was all smiles; she was proud of me for the first time. I had to leave the nursery. I had a premonition, that this was not the first time I was going to be thrown out of places; not because of aggression, which was not my style, but for independent or unconventional thinking.

During the summer holidays in Vrbas, she taught me to swim in the ship canal. Golden sand was brought in from the Adriatic to form a little beach, with trees planted in the background. It was lovely and civilised.

It did not take me long to learn to swim, but I had only just managed to learn to stay afloat when my mother took me downstream to a dam. There were some 12 to 14-year-old boys jumping from at least a four metre height into the water. My mother knew the place well. It was one of her favourite haunts and she insisted that I too should jump. I was absolutely terrified, but I did it. To my great surprise, I surfaced unharmed. I am not sure what those big boys thought of it, but they would have seen that my mother was there to help out if there was a problem. Similar cases followed, and by then I was getting stronger and fitter and keen to impress my mother, who was very critical of my posture and way of walking.

She also taught me to ski, which was one of her great passions. I found skiing difficult as my boots were bought several sizes too large, so as to last longer. Nevertheless, after showing me the slalom, she left me to descend on my own, on a gentler slope, while she glided elegantly on a steep run to a little cafe at the bottom of the valley.

Many times, I ended face down in the soft snow and was almost crying when I finally made it to the café. All the grown-ups were by then seated in the conservatory and they started to clap. I was treated to the speciality of the house, a frothed-up chocolate drink with shavings of real chocolate on top. Years later, as a teenager, I met my first boyfriend Ervin Gabor on the same slope. I am still in touch with him all these years later. I also had a near fatal accident on the same slope, twisting my knee when I was 16 years old. I bandaged my knee with my scarf and somehow managed to get home by tram. I took a bath to relax, and had a stroke from the blood clot, which settled in my brain. I was between life and death, for a couple of weeks, attended to by my father and his specialist colleagues. The blood clot is still in my brain and affects me still.

As a child, my mother took me to dance and music classes, museums and to the movies. I saw *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* and *The Wizard of Oz* several times each

My mother was rather sarcastic and critical of me most of the time. The only area which escaped her rather constant wounding reproaches was my artwork.

There were not many materials available for children in those days, just pencil and paper.

However, I was convinced that I was going to be an artist. Magda patiently posed for me in the most uncomfortable positions as an artist's model and appreciated the rather surreal art work which emerged. I still remember a weird drawing of nude nuns with large white head dresses or coifs and black crosses round their necks dancing wildly about. This drawing, which looked like a clip from a film by Federico Fellini, found its way into my diary together with portraits of my friends.

I certainly had plenty of artistic inspiration. My mother took me to see the wonderful collections of the Museum of Fine Arts, and there might have been books on art history or encyclopaedias in my father's library, where I would also have picked up ideas or ways of representing the human figure from all the medical texts. I was sure that art was what I was going to do all my life and it is reassuring to go back to the very themes and preoccupations which still fascinate me.